

測圓海鏡

Sea Mirror of Circle Measurements

卷一—卷三 | Volumes I–III

BILINGUAL EDITION — 雙語版

Original Chinese • English Translation

元 李冶 撰

(Li Ye / Li Zhi, 1192–1279)

以天元術解勾股容圓一百七十問

*Using the Method of the Celestial Element (Tian Yuan Shu)
to Solve 170 Problems on the Inscribed Circle*

A foundational text of medieval Chinese algebra,
completed in the year 1248 of the Common Era.

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1 Introduction / 引言

測圓海鏡簡介

《測圓海鏡》乃李冶（李冶，1192–1279）之傑作。李冶為宋元四大數學家之一，與楊輝、秦九韶、朱世傑齊名。此書成於 1248 年，系統運用**天元術**（多項式代數方法）求解圓與直角三角形相關之一百七十問。全書結構如下：

- **卷一**：理論基礎——圓城圖式、總率名號、今問正數、識別雜記（含六百九十二條幾何公式）
- **卷二至卷十二**：一百七十問，以天元術求解，方程次數自一次至六次。

本文檔包含**卷一至卷三**之全文，即全部基礎理論及首批問題。

Introduction

The *Ceyuan Haijing* (測圓海鏡, literally “Sea Mirror of Circle Measurements”) is the masterpiece of Li Ye (李冶, also known as Li Zhi, 1192–1279), one of the four great mathematicians of the Song–Yuan period of China, alongside Yang Hui, Qin Jiushao, and Zhu Shijie.

Completed in 1248, this work systematically applies the **tian yuan shu** (天元術, “method of the celestial element”)—an algebraic method for setting up and solving polynomial equations—to a total of 170 geometric problems concerning a circle inscribed in or related to a right triangle (勾股容圓).

The book is organized as follows:

- **Volume 1** establishes the theoretical foundation: the *Circle City Diagram* (圓城圖式), the *General Rate Names* (總率名號), the *Current Question Numbers* (今問正數), and the *Identification Miscellaneous Records* (識別雜記) containing 692 geometric formulas.
- **Volumes 2–12** present 170 problems, solved by the **tian yuan shu** method. The problems involve equations of degrees ranging from 1 to 6.

The present document contains the complete text of **Volumes 1–3**, comprising all foundational material and the first suite of problems.

2 Original Preface / 原序

原序

數本難窮，吾欲以力強窮之，彼其數不惟不能得其凡，而吾之力且憊矣。然則數果不可以窮耶？既已名之數矣，則又何為而不可窮也。

故謂數為難窮斯可，謂數為不可窮斯不可。何則？彼其冥冥之中，固有昭昭者存，夫昭昭者其自然之數也。非自然之數，其自然之理也。數一出於自然，吾欲以力強窮之，使隸首復生亦末如之何也已。

苟能推自然之理，以明自然之數，則雖遠而乾端坤倪，幽而神情鬼狀，未有不合者矣。

予自幼喜算數，恆病夫考圓之術例出於牽強，殊乖於自然，如古率、徽率、密率之不同，截弧、截矢、截背之互見，內外諸角，析剖支條，莫不各自名家，與世作法。及反覆研究，卒無以當吾心焉。

老大以來，得洞淵九容之說，日夕玩繹，而向之病我者，使爆然落去而無遺余。山中多暇，客有從余求其說者，於是乎又為衍之，遂累一百七十問。

既成編，客復目之《測圓海鏡》，蓋取夫天臨海鏡之義也。

Original Preface

Numbers are fundamentally difficult to exhaust; if I try to force them by effort, not only will I fail to apprehend their essence, but my strength will be depleted as well. Yet can numbers truly not be exhausted? Since they are already called *numbers*, why then could they not be exhausted?

It is acceptable to say that numbers are difficult to exhaust; but it is unacceptable to say they cannot be exhausted. Why? In the midst of darkness, there is indeed brightness. That brightness is the natural number. It is not merely the natural number—it is the natural principle. Since numbers arise from nature, if I try to force them by effort, even if Li Shou (the legendary inventor of arithmetic) were reborn, he could do no better.

If one can extend natural principles to illuminate natural numbers, then even things as distant as the corners of heaven and earth, or as mysterious as spirits and ghosts, will all be in agreement.

Since youth I have delighted in arithmetic. I was always troubled that the methods for investigating circles seemed forced and artificial, contrary to nature—the ancient rate, Hui's rate, and the close rate all differing; the arc, sagitta, and back each being considered separately; the internal and external angles analyzed into minute subdivisions—each school establishing its own name and method for the world. After repeated study, none could satisfy my mind.

In old age, I obtained the *Dongyuan Nine Containments* (洞淵九容) theory, and pondered it day and night. What had previously troubled me suddenly fell away completely, leaving no trace. With leisure time in the mountains, when guests asked me to explain this theory, I expanded upon it, eventually accumulating **one hundred and seventy problems**.

When the compilation was complete, a guest named it *Ceyuan Haijing*—taking the meaning of “heaven overlooking the sea mirror.”

昔半山老人集《唐百家詩選》，自謂廢日力於此，良可惜。明道先生以上蔡謝君記誦為玩物喪志。夫文史尚矣，猶之為不足貴，況九九賤技能乎！

嗜好酸鹹，平生每痛自戒勅，竟莫能已，類有物憑之者，吾亦不知其然而然也。

故嘗私為之解曰：由技兼於事者言之，夷之禮，夔之樂，亦不免為一技。由技進乎道者言之，石之斤，扁之輪，非聖人之所與乎。

覽吾之編，察吾苦心，其憫我者當百數，其笑我者當千數。乃若吾之所自得，則自得焉耳，寧復為人憫笑計哉。

李冶序

In the past, the Old Man of Banshan compiled the *Anthology of One Hundred Tang Poets*, saying that to waste his days on such a thing was truly a pity. Master Mingdao criticized Xie of Shangcai for memorizing texts as “playing with things and losing one’s ambition.” Literature and history are esteemed subjects, yet even they are considered not worth valuing—how much less the lowly skill of multiplication!

My fondness for such sour and salty pursuits—throughout my life I have sternly admonished myself against them, yet in the end I could not stop, as if some force were driving me. I myself do not know why it is so.

So I have privately explained it thus: speaking from the perspective of skills combined with affairs, even the rites of Yi and the music of Kui were not exempt from being a single skill. Speaking from the perspective of advancing from skill to the Way, was not the stone-axe of [the sage] and the wheel of Bian [the wheelwright] praised by the sages?

Those who read my compilation and perceive my earnest efforts—those who pity me will number in the hundreds, those who laugh at me will number in the thousands. As for what I myself have gained, I have simply gained it; how could I calculate for the sake of being pitied or laughed at?

— Preface by Li Ye

3 Volume 1 / 卷一

卷一為全書之理論基礎，分為四大部分：

1. 圓城圖式——主幾何圖形
2. 總率名號——十五個直角三角形及其元素之定義
3. 今問正數——各線段之數值
4. 識別雜記——六百九十二條幾何公式

3.1 Circle City Diagram / 圓城圖式

圓城圖式為一百七十問所基之主幾何圖形。其構為一大直角三角形（勾股形），內切一圓，並設特定之點與線。

其情境如下：

假令有圓城一所，不知周徑，四面開門，門外縱橫各有十字大道。其西北十字道頭定為乾地，其東北十字道頭定為艮地，其東南十字道頭定為巽地，其西南十字道頭定為坤地。所有測望雜法一一設問如後。

二十二名點 / The 22 Named Points

最大直角三角形之頂點為天、地、乾。內切圓之心稱心。各點以單字命名：

天	地	乾	心	日	南	北	川
東	西	艮	坤	山	月	巽	青
泉	朱	金	泛	旦	夕		

3.2 General Rate Names / 總率名號

全書研究十五個直角三角形，皆以天地線之一段為弦（弦，即斜邊）。總率名號定義各三角形之三邊。每個三角形：

- 弦 (c) ——斜邊
- 股 (b) ——較長之直邊
- 勾 (a) ——較短之直邊

Volume 1 is the theoretical foundation of the entire work. It comprises four major sections:

1. **Circle City Diagram** (圓城圖式) – the master geometric configuration
2. **General Rate Names** (總率名號) – definitions of all 15 right triangles and their elements
3. **Current Question Numbers** (今問正數) – numerical values for all line segments
4. **Identification Miscellaneous Records** (識別雜記) – 692 geometric formulas

The *Circle City Diagram* is the master geometric configuration upon which all 170 problems are based. It consists of a large right triangle (called 勾股形, “leg-leg shape”) with its inscribed circle, together with specific points and lines.

The scenario Li Ye constructs is:

Suppose there is a circular city whose circumference and diameter are unknown. It has gates on all four sides, and outside each gate there are crossroads running north-south and east-west. The northwest crossroad is designated **Qian** (乾), the northeast **Gen** (艮), the southeast **Xun** (巽), and the southwest **Kun** (坤). All surveying methods are set forth as questions below.

The largest right triangle has vertices **Tian** (天, Heaven), **Di** (地, Earth), and **Qian** (乾). The center of the inscribed circle is called **Xin** (心, Heart). Key points include intersections of horizontal and vertical lines through the center and other constructed lines. Each point is designated by a single Chinese character:

Tian	Di	Qian	Xin	Ri	Nan	Bei	Chuan
Dong	Xi	Gen	Kun	Shan	Yue	Xun	Qing
Quan	Zhu	Jin	Fan	Dan	Xi		

The work studies 15 **right triangles**, all having a segment of the *Tiandi* (天地) line as their hypotenuse (弦, “string”). The *General Rate Names* define these triangles and their three sides.

In each triangle:

- 弦 (c) – the hypotenuse (斜邊)
- 股 (b) – the longer vertical leg
- 勾 (a) – the shorter horizontal leg

十五三角形表 / Table of 15 Triangles

	No.	名稱 / Name	頂點 / Vertices	弦	股	勾
1	通 (Tong/General)	天-地-乾	通弦	通股	通勾	
2	邊 (Bian/Side)	天-西-川	邊弦	邊股	邊勾	
3	底 (Di/Base)	日-地-北	底弦	底股	底勾	
4	黃廣 (Huangguang)	天-山-金	黃廣弦	黃廣股	黃廣勾	
5	黃長 (Huangchang)	月-地-泉	黃長弦	黃長股	黃長勾	
6	上高 (Shanggao)	天-日-旦	上高弦	上高股	上高勾	
7	下高 (Xiagao)	日-山-朱	下高弦	下高股	下高勾	
8	上平 (Shangping)	月-川-青	上平弦	上平股	上平勾	
9	下平 (Xiaping)	川-地-夕	下平弦	下平股	下平勾	
10	大差 (Dacha)	天-月-坤	大差弦	大差股	大差勾	
11	小差 (Xiaocha)	山-地-艮	小差弦	小差股	小差勾	
12	皇極 (Huangji)	日-川-心	皇極弦	皇極股	皇極勾	
13	太虛 (Taixu)	月-山-泛	太虛弦	太虛股	太虛勾	
14	明 (Ming)	日-月-南	明弦	明股	明勾	
15	夷 (Zhuan)	山-川-東	夷弦	夷股	夷勾	

注：上高 = 下高，上平 = 下平，故十五三角形中實僅十三個互異。

Note: 上高 = 下高 and 上平 = 下平, so among 15 triangles, only 13 are distinct.

3.3 Current Question Numbers / 今問正數

此節給出圖中每條線段之數值。內切圓之半徑定為一百二十步，作為標準單位。

This section gives the numerical value of every line segment in the diagram. The radius of the inscribed circle is taken as 120 steps (步), which serves as the standard unit.

1. 通 (Tong / 通用)

弦六百八十	勾三百二十	股六百
勾股和九百二十	較二百八十	
勾和一千	較三百六十	
股和一千二百八十	較八十	
較和九百六十	較四百	
和和一千六百	較二百四十	

1. Tong (General)

Hypotenuse 680	Short leg 320, Long leg 920
Sum of legs 920	Difference 280
Leg-hypotenuse sum 1000	Difference 360
Leg-hypotenuse sum 1280	Difference 80
Difference-sum 960	Difference 400
Sum-sum 1600	Difference 240

That is: hypotenuse $c = 680$, short leg $a = 320$, long leg $b = 920$.

2. 邊 (Bian / Side)

弦五百四十四	勾二百五十六	股四百八十
勾股和七百三十六	較二百二十四	
勾和八百	較二百八十八	
股和一千零二十四	較六十四	
較和七百六十八	較三百二十	
和和一千二百八十	較一百九十二	

2. Bian (Side)

Hypotenuse 544	Short leg 256, Long leg 480
Sum of legs 736	Difference 224
Leg-hypotenuse sum 800	Difference 288
Leg-hypotenuse sum 1024	Difference 64
Difference-sum 768	Difference 320
Sum-sum 1280	Difference 192

3. 底 (Di / Base)

弦四百二十五	勾二百	股三百七十五
勾股和五百七十五	較一百七十五	
勾和六百二十五	較二百二十五	
股和八百	較五十	
較和六百	較二百五十	
和和一千	較一百五十	

3. Di (Base)

Hypotenuse 425	Short leg 200, Long leg 375
Sum of legs 575	Difference 175
Leg-hypotenuse sum 625	Difference 225
Leg-hypotenuse sum 800	Difference 50
Difference-sum 600	Difference 250
Sum-sum 1000	Difference 150

4. 黃廣 (Huang Guang)

弦五百一十 勾二百四十 股四百五十
 (即城徑也)
勾股和六百九十 較二百一十

其餘十一三角形依同樣模式，每個十三個數量（弦、勾、股、勾股和、勾股較、勾弦和、勾弦較、股弦和、股弦較、弦較和、弦較較、弦和和、弦和較），共 $15 \times 13 = 195$ 個數值條目。

4. Huang Guang

Hypotenuse 510 Short leg 240, Long leg 450
 (this is the city diameter)
Sum of legs 690 Difference 210

The remaining 11 triangles follow the same pattern, each with 13 numerical quantities (弦, 勾, 股, 勾股和, 勾股較, 勾弦和, 勾弦較, 股弦和, 股弦較, 弦較和, 弦較較, 弦和和, 弦和較), giving a total of $15 \times 13 = 195$ numerical entries.

3.4 Identification Miscellaneous Records / 識別雜記

此為全書之理論核心，含**六百九十二條幾何公式**，關聯圖中各線段。此等公式純為幾何定理，與具體數值無關。後續各卷之問題皆以此等公式配合天元術求解。本分為八部分：

- 1. 諸雜名目——一般定義及三十餘條定理
- 2. 五和五較
- 3. 諸弦
- 4. 大小差
- 5. 諸差
- 6. 諸率互見
- 7. 四位拾遺
- 8. 拾遺

諸雜名目示例：

This is the theoretical heart of the work. It contains **692 geometric formulas** relating the various line segments in the diagram. These formulas are purely geometric theorems, independent of any particular numerical values. The problems in all subsequent volumes are solved by using these formulas together with the tian yuan shu. The section is divided into eight parts:

- 1. Various Names (諸雜名目) – general definitions and 30+ theorems
- 2. Five Sums and Five Differences (五和五較)
- 3. Various Hypotenuses (諸弦)
- 4. Large and Small Differences (大小差)
- 5. Various Differences (諸差)
- 6. Mutual Relations of Rates (諸率互見)
- 7. Four-Place Supplement (四位拾遺)
- 8. Supplement (拾遺)

Sample Definitions from Various Names:

名稱 / Name	定義 / Definition
內率	明勾 × 裏股 / Ming 勾 × Zhuan 股
外率	明股 × 裏勾 / Ming 股 × Zhuan 勾
虛率	虛勾 × 虛股 / Xu 勾 × Xu 股
角差	高股 – 平勾 / Gao 股 – Ping 勾
次差	(明股 – 明勾) + (裏股 – 裏勾)
混同和	黃長股 + 黃廣勾 / Huangchang 股 + Huangguang 勾
傍差	(明股 – 明勾) – (裏股 – 裏勾)

定理示例：

Sample Theorems:

- 凡大差小差相乘為半段徑幂。
 - 大差勾小差股相乘同上。
 - 黃廣股黃長勾相乘為經幂。
 - 勾股和即弦黃和。
- The product of the large difference and small difference equals half the square of the diameter.
 - The product of the large-difference short-leg and the small-difference long-leg equals the same.
 - The product of the Huangguang long-leg and Huangchang short-leg equals the square of the diameter.
 - The sum of the two legs equals the sum of the hypotenuse and the diameter of the inscribed circle: $a + b = c + d$, where d is the diameter of the inscribed circle.

4 Volume 2 / 卷二

正率一十四問

此十四問構成「洞淵九容」序列，源自道教大師李思聰（號洞淵）之著作。其呈現直角三角形中九種基本容圖類型，另加五題。

4.0.1 第一問 / Problem 1

問 甲乙二人俱在乾地，乙東行三百二十步而立，甲南行六百步望見乙，問徑幾里？

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為勾股容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，並勾股幕以求弦，復加入勾股共，以為法。

草 置甲南行六百步在地，以乙東行三百二十步乘之，得一十九萬二千步，倍之得三十萬四千步為實。以乙東行步自之，得一十萬零二千四百步為勾幕；以甲南行步自之，得三十六萬步為股幕。二幕相並，得四十六萬二千四百步為方實，以平方開之，得六百八十步，則弦也。以弦加勾股共，共得一千六百步以為法。如法而一，得二百四十步，則城徑也。合問。

4.0.2 第二問 / Problem 2

問 甲乙二人俱在西門，乙東行二百五十六步，甲南行四百八十步望見乙，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為勾上容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，並勾股幕以求弦，加入股以為法。

草 置甲南行四百八十步在地，以乙東行二百五十六步乘之，得一十二萬二千八百八十步，倍之得二十四萬五千七百六十步為實。以乙東行步自之，得六萬五千五百三十六步為勾幕；以甲南行步自之，得二十三萬零四百步為股幕。勾股幕相並，得二十九萬五千九百三十六步為方實，以平方開之，得五百四十四步為弦也。以弦加入南行步，共得一千零二十四步以為法。而一，得二百四十步則城徑。合問。

Fourteen Questions on Standard Rates

These fourteen problems form the “Dongyuan Nine Containments” (洞淵九容) sequence, derived from the earlier work of the Daoist master Li Sicong (李思聰, known as “Master Dongyuan”). They present the nine fundamental types of circles contained in or related to a right triangle, plus five additional problems.

Problem. Two people, A and B, both stand at Qian. B walks 320 steps east and stops. A walks 600 steps south and sees B. What is the diameter?

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle contained in the right triangle” case. Multiply the two legs and double it to obtain the dividend. Combine the squares of the legs to find the hypotenuse, then add the sum of the legs to form the divisor.

Working. Place A’s 600 steps south. Multiply by B’s 320 steps east, obtaining 192,000 steps; double to get 384,000 as the dividend. Square B’s eastward steps to get 102,400 as the short-leg square; square A’s southward steps to get 360,000 as the long-leg square. Add the two squares: 462,400. Extract the square root to get 680, which is the hypotenuse. Add the sum of the legs to the hypotenuse: 1,600 as the divisor. Divide: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees with the question.

Problem. Two people both stand at the West Gate. B walks 256 steps east, A walks 480 steps south and sees B. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle on the short leg” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Combine the squares of the legs to find the hypotenuse; add the long leg as divisor.

Working. Place A’s 480 steps south. Multiply by B’s 256 steps east, obtaining 122,880; double to get 245,760 as dividend. Square B’s eastward steps: 65,536 as the short-leg square. Square A’s southward steps: 230,400 as the long-leg square. Combine: 295,936. Extract square root: 544, the hypotenuse. Add the southward steps: 1,024 as divisor. Divide: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

4.0.3 第三問 / Problem 3

問 甲乙二人俱在北門，乙東行二百步而止，甲南行三百七十五步望見乙，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為股上容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以勾股羈求弦，加入勾以為法。

草 置甲南行三百七十五步，以乙東行二百步乘之，得七萬五千步，倍之得一十五萬步為實。以乙東行自之，得四萬步為勾羈；以甲南行自之，得一十四萬零六百二十五步為股羈。勾股羈相並，得一十八萬零六百二十五步為方實。如平方而一，得四百二十五步則弦也。加入乙東行二百步，共得六百二十五步以為法。以法除之，得二百四十步，則城徑也。合問。

Problem. Two people both stand at the North Gate. B walks 200 steps east and stops. A walks 375 steps south and sees B. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle on the long leg” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the squares of the legs to find the hypotenuse; add the short leg as divisor.

Working. Place A's 375 steps south. Multiply by B's 200 steps east: 75,000; double to get 150,000 as dividend. Square B's eastward steps: 40,000 as the short-leg square. Square A's southward steps: 140,625 as the long-leg square. Combine: 180,625. Extract square root: 425, the hypotenuse. Add B's 200 eastward steps: 625 as divisor. Divide: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

4.0.4 第四問 / Problem 4

問 甲乙二人俱在圓城中心而立，乙穿城向東行一百三十六步而止，甲穿城南行二百五十五步望見乙，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為勾股上容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，並勾股羈如法求弦，以為法。

草 以二行步相乘，得三萬四千六百八十步，倍之得六萬九千三百六十步為實。置乙東行自之，得一萬八千四百九十六步為勾羈；又以甲南行自之，得六萬五千零二十五步為股羈。二羈相並，得八萬三千五百二十一步為方實，以平方開之，得二百八十九步即弦也。便以為法。如法除實，得二百四十步，即圓城之徑也。合問。

Problem. Two people both stand at the center of the circular city. B goes through the city, walking 136 steps east and stops. A goes through the city, walking 255 steps south and sees B. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle on both legs” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Combine the squares of the legs to find the hypotenuse as divisor.

Working. Multiply the two walking distances: 34,680; double to get 69,360 as dividend. Square B's eastward steps: 18,496 as the short-leg square. Square A's southward steps: 65,025 as the long-leg square. Combine: 83,521. Extract square root: 289, the hypotenuse. This serves as the divisor. Divide: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

4.0.5 第五問 / Problem 5

問 甲乙二人同立於乾地，乙東行一百八十步遇塔而止，甲南行三百六十步，回望其塔正居城徑之半，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為弦上容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以勾股和為法。

草 以二行步相乘，得六萬四千八百步，倍之得一十二萬九千六百步為實。並二行步，得五百四十步以為法。除實，得二百四十步，即城徑也。合問。

Problem. Two people stand together at Qian. B walks 180 steps east and reaches a pagoda. A walks 360 steps south and looks back: the pagoda lies exactly at half the city diameter. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle on the hypotenuse” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the sum of the legs as divisor.

Working. Multiply the two walking distances: 64,800; double to get 129,600 as dividend. Add the two distances: 540 as divisor. Divide: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

4.0.6 第六問 / Problem 6

問 甲乙二人俱在坤地，乙東行一百九十二步而止，甲南行三百六十步，望乙與城參相直，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為勾外容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以弦較和為法。

草 以二行步相乘，得六萬九千一百二十步，倍之得一十三萬八千二百四十步為實。置乙東行自之，得三萬六千八百六十四步為勾羈；又置甲南行自之，得一十二萬九千六百步為股羈。二羈相並，得一十六萬六千四百六十四步為方實，以平方開之，得四百零八，即弦也。又置甲南行步內減乙東行步，餘一百六十八步，即較也。以較加弦，共得五百七十六步以為法。實如法而一，得二百四十步，為城徑也。合問。

[按] 此題用勾股求得弦，即可加減得弦較較為城徑。今必以勾股相乘倍積為實，求得弦較和為法，而後始得弦較較為城徑者，蓋欲因此並明勾股相乘之倍積為弦較較、弦較和相乘之積，非故為紆回也。

Problem. Two people both stand at Kun. B walks 192 steps east and stops. A walks 360 steps south and sees B aligned with the city. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle outside the short leg” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the sum of hypotenuse and difference as divisor.

Working. Multiply the two walking distances: 69,120; double to get 138,240 as dividend. Square B’s eastward steps: 36,864 as the short-leg square. Square A’s southward steps: 129,600 as the long-leg square. Combine: 166,464. Extract square root: 408, the hypotenuse. Subtract B’s steps from A’s: 168, the difference. Add difference to hypotenuse: 576 as divisor. Divide: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

[Explanatory note: This problem uses the right triangle to find the hypotenuse, then by addition and subtraction obtains the “hypotenuse-difference-difference” as the city diameter. The method deliberately uses the product of the legs (doubled) as dividend to demonstrate that this product equals the product of (hypotenuse–difference) and (hypotenuse+difference).]

4.0.7 第七問 / Problem 7

問 甲乙二人同立於艮地，甲南行一百五十步而止，乙東行八十步，望乙與城參相直，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為股外容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以弦和較為法。

Problem. Two people stand together at Gen. A walks 150 steps south and stops. B walks 80 steps east. A sees B aligned with the city. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle outside the long leg” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the difference of hypotenuse-sum as divisor.

4.0.8 第八問 / Problem 8

問 甲乙二人同立於坤地，甲南行一百九十二步而止，乙東行七十二步，望乙與城參相直，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為弦外容圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以勾股較為法。

Problem. Two people stand together at Kun. A walks 192 steps south and stops. B walks 72 steps east. A sees B aligned with the city. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “circle outside the hypotenuse” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the difference of the legs as divisor.

4.0.9 第九問 / Problem 9

問 甲乙二人俱在異地，乙東行一百九十二步而止，甲南行三百六十步，望乙與城參相直，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為勾外容半圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以股弦和為法。

Problem. Two people both stand at Xun. B walks 192 steps east and stops. A walks 360 steps south. A sees B aligned with the city. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “semicircle outside the short leg” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the sum of long leg and hypotenuse as divisor.

4.0.10 第十問 / Problem 10

問 甲乙二人俱在艮地，甲南行一百五十步而止，乙東行八十步，望乙與城參相直，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 此為股外容半圓也。以勾股相乘，倍之為實，以勾弦和為法。

Problem. Two people both stand at Gen. A walks 150 steps south and stops. B walks 80 steps east. A sees B aligned with the city. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. This is the “semicircle outside the long leg” case. Multiply the two legs and double as dividend. Use the sum of short leg and hypotenuse as divisor.

以上十問構成「洞淵九容」，第五問（弦上容圓）為補充。卷二其餘四問繼續以天元術求解之標準率問題。

The above ten problems constitute the “Dongyuan Nine Containments” (洞淵九容), supplemented by Problem 5 (circle on the hypotenuse). The remaining four problems of Volume 2 continue with additional standard-rate problems using the tian yuan shu method.

5 Volume 3 / 卷三

邊股一十七問

卷三呈十七問，所給數據涉及邊股 (b_2)，定義為「邊」三角形（表中第二）之長直邊，等於四百八十步。本卷所有問題之未知數皆為圓城直徑（城徑 = 二百四十步）。此等問題展示天元術之漸增精妙，方程次數自二次至三次。

5.0.1 第一問 / Problem 1

問 乙出東門南行，不知步數而止。甲出西門南行四百八十步，望見乙，復就乙行五百一十步與乙相會，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 倍相減步，以乘二之甲南行步，為平方實，得城徑。

草 識別得二行相減，餘三十步，即乙出東門南行步也。倍相減步，得六十步，以乘二之甲南行步九百六十步，得五萬七千六百步，為平方實。如法開之，得二百四十步，即城徑也。合問。

Seventeen Questions on the Side-Long-Leg

Volume 3 presents 17 problems in which the given data involve the *side long-leg* (邊股, b_2), defined as the long leg of the “Side” triangle (邊 triangle, No. 2 in the table), equal to 480 steps. In all problems of this volume, the unknown to be found is the diameter of the circular city (城徑 = 240 steps). These problems demonstrate the increasing sophistication of the tian yuan shu method, with equations ranging from quadratic to cubic degree.

Problem. B goes out the East Gate and walks south, an unknown number of steps, then stops. A goes out the West Gate and walks 480 steps south, sees B, then walks 510 steps to reach B. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. Double the difference of the two walking distances; multiply by twice A’s southward steps to obtain the square-root dividend; this gives the city diameter.

Working. Recognize: subtracting the two distances leaves 30 steps, which is B’s southward distance from the East Gate. Double the difference: 60 steps. Multiply by twice A’s southward steps (960): 57,600, the square-root dividend. Extract the square root: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

5.0.2 第二問 / Problem 2

問 甲出西門南行四百八十步而止，乙從艮隅東行八十步，望見甲，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 倍南行步，以東行步乘之為實，東行步為從方，一步常法，得全徑。

草 立天元一為全徑，以減於二之甲南行步，得為兩個大差也。以乙東行步乘之，得為圓徑冪，寄左。然後以天元冪與左相消，得以帶縱平方開之，得二百四十步，即城徑也。合問。

又法：半之乙東行步，乘南行步為實，半之乙東行步為從，一步常法，得半徑。

草 立天元一為半城徑，減甲南行步，得為大差也。以半之東行步乘之，得即半徑冪，寄左。然後以天元冪為同數，與左相消，得開帶縱平方，得一百二十步。倍之，即城徑也。合問。

Problem. A goes out the West Gate and walks 480 steps south, then stops. B walks 80 steps east from the Gen corner and sees A. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. Double the southward steps; multiply by the eastward steps as dividend; the eastward steps as the “following square”; unity as the constant method; obtain the full diameter.

Working. Set the celestial element unity as the full diameter. Subtract from twice A’s southward steps to obtain two large differences. Multiply by B’s eastward steps to obtain the circle-diameter square; store on the left. Then cancel the celestial element square with the left; extract the square root with a following edge: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

Alternative Method: Halve B’s eastward steps; multiply by the southward steps as dividend; halved eastward steps as the following term; unity as constant method; obtain the radius.

Working. Set the celestial element unity as half the city diameter. Subtract from A’s southward steps to obtain the large difference. Multiply by halved eastward steps to obtain the radius square; store on the left. Then use the celestial element square as the equal number; cancel with the left; extract the square root with a following edge: 120 steps. Double it: the city diameter. This agrees.

5.0.3 第三問 / Problem 3

問 甲出西門南行四百八十步而止，乙從艮隅亦南行一百五十步，望見甲，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 兩行步相乘為實，南行步為從方，一為隅，得半徑。

草 立天元一為半城徑，以減乙南行步，得為半梯頭；以甲行步為梯底，以乘之，得為半徑冪，寄左。然後以天元冪與左相消，得開帶縱平方，得一百二十步。倍之，即城徑也。合問。

Problem. A goes out the West Gate and walks 480 steps south, then stops. B also walks 150 steps south from the Gen corner and sees A. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. Multiply the two walking distances as dividend; the southward steps as the “following square”; unity as the corner; obtain the radius.

Working. Set the celestial element unity as half the city diameter. Subtract from B’s southward steps to obtain half the trapezoid head. Use A’s steps as the trapezoid base; multiply to obtain the radius square; store on the left. Then cancel the celestial element square with the left; extract the square root with a following edge: 120 steps. Double it: the city diameter. This agrees.

5.0.4 第四問 / Problem 4

問 甲出西門南行四百八十步，乙出東門直行一十六步，望見甲，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 以四之東行步，乘南行冪為實，從空，東行為廉，一步為隅法，得全徑。

草 立天元一為圓徑，加乙東行步，得為中勾；其甲南行即中股也。置東行步為小勾，以中股乘之，得，合以中勾除，今不受除，便以為小股也。內寄中勾分母。乃復以中股乘之，得三百六十八萬六千四百，又四之，得一千四百七十四萬五千六百，為一段圓徑冪，寄中勾分母，寄左。然後以天元徑自之，又以中勾乘之，得為同數，與左相消，得以帶縱立方開之，得二百四十步，為城徑也。合問。

[按] 不受除者，無可除之理也。凡二數，此數於彼數有可除之理，則受除；無可除之理，則不受除也。蓋除有法有實，實可二，法不可二。此題以中勾為法，而中勾內有一元，又有十六步，其為數已二矣，又何以均分不一之數乎？故曰不受也。寄分者，姑寄其應除之數也。俟求得兩相等數，而此數內尚少一除，不除此而轉乘彼，則兩數仍相等，猶之受除者也。此所謂以乘代除也。

Problem. A goes out the West Gate and walks 480 steps south. B goes out the East Gate and walks 16 steps straight, and sees A. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. Multiply four times the eastward steps by the square of the southward steps as dividend; the “following” term is empty; the eastward steps as the edge; unity as the corner method; obtain the full diameter.

Working. Set the celestial element unity as the circle diameter. Add B’s eastward steps to obtain the middle short-leg. A’s southward steps are the middle long-leg. Place the eastward steps as the small short-leg; multiply by the middle long-leg. This should be divided by the middle short-leg, but it is “not accepted for division”—use it directly as the small long-leg, with the middle short-leg as denominator. Multiply again by the middle long-leg: 3,686,400; multiply by 4: 14,745,600 as a segment of the circle-diameter square, with the middle short-leg as denominator; store on the left. Then square the celestial element diameter and multiply by the middle short-leg as the equal number; cancel with the left; extract the cube root with a following edge: 240 steps, the city diameter. This agrees.

[Explanatory note: “Not accepted for division” means there is no valid way to divide. When two numbers are such that one can be divided by the other, the division is “accepted”; otherwise it is “not accepted.” For division has divisor and dividend; the dividend can be compound, but the divisor cannot. Here the middle short-leg serves as divisor, but it contains both the celestial element and 16 steps—it is already compound. How can one evenly divide a non-uniform number? Hence “not accepted.” Storing the denominator means temporarily retaining the number that should be divided. When two equal quantities are found, and one still lacks a division, instead of dividing this, multiply that; the two quantities remain equal, as if the division had been accepted. This is the so-called “substituting multiplication for division.”]

5.0.5 第五問 / Problem 5

問 乙出南門東行七十二步而止，甲出西門南行四百八十步，望乙與城參相直，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

術 以乙東行冪，乘甲南行為實；乙東行冪為從方；甲南行步內減二之東行步為益廉；一步常法，得半徑。

草 立天元一為半城徑，以減南行步，得為小股。又以天元加乙東行步，得為小勾。又以天元加南行步，得為大股。乃置大股在地，以小勾乘之，得下式，合以小股除之，今不受除，便以為大勾，內寄小股分母。又置天元半徑，以分母小股乘之，得以減大勾，得為半個梯底於上。以乙東行七十二步為半個梯頭，以乘上位，得為半徑冪，內寄小股分母，寄左。然後置天元冪，又以分母小股乘之，得為同數，與左相消，以立方開之，得一百二十步。倍之，即城徑也。合問。

又法：以二數相乘為實，相減為從，一虛法，平開，得半徑。

Problem. B goes out the South Gate and walks 72 steps east, then stops. A goes out the West Gate and walks 480 steps south. A sees B aligned with the city. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

Method. Multiply the square of B's eastward steps by A's southward steps as dividend; the square of B's eastward steps as the "following square"; subtract twice the eastward steps from A's southward steps as the "beneficial edge"; unity as the constant method; obtain the radius.

Working. Set the celestial element unity as half the city diameter. Subtract from the southward steps to obtain the small long-leg. Add the celestial element to B's eastward steps to obtain the small short-leg. Add the celestial element to the southward steps to obtain the large long-leg. Place the large long-leg; multiply by the small short-leg. This should be divided by the small long-leg, but it is "not accepted for division"—use it directly as the large short-leg, with the small long-leg as denominator. Place the celestial element radius; multiply by the denominator (small long-leg); subtract from the large short-leg to obtain half the trapezoid base on top. Use B's 72 eastward steps as half the trapezoid head; multiply the upper quantity to obtain the radius square, with the small long-leg as denominator; store on the left. Then place the celestial element square; multiply by the denominator (small long-leg) as the equal number; cancel with the left; extract the cube root: 120 steps. Double it: the city diameter. This agrees.

Alternative Method: Multiply the two numbers as dividend; their difference as the following term; unity as the empty method; extract the square root; obtain the radius.

5.0.6 第六問 / Problem 6

問 乙出南門東行，不知步數而立。甲出西門南行四百八十步，望見乙與城參相直，又就乙行四百零八步與乙相會，問答同前。

答 城徑二百四十步。

[其餘十一問依同樣模式，所給數據涉及邊股（邊股 = 四百八十步）及其他各種測量，每問皆以天元術建立多項式方程，求解得城徑二百四十步。]

Problem. B goes out the South Gate and walks east, an unknown number of steps, then stands. A goes out the West Gate and walks 480 steps south, sees B aligned with the city, then walks 408 steps to reach B. Answer as before.

Answer. The city diameter is 240 steps.

[The remaining 11 problems of Volume 3 continue in the same pattern, with given data involving the side long-leg (邊股 = 480 steps) and various other measurements, each leading to polynomial equations solved by the tian yuan shu method to yield the city diameter of 240 steps.]

6 The Tian Yuan Shu Method / 天元術

天元術

天元術（「天元術」，「method of the celestial element」）為《測圓海鏡》全書所運用之代數技法。此乃中國數學史上最早之系統方法，用以建立並求解一元多項式方程。

6.1 Methodology / 方法論

其程序如下：

1. **立天元一為 X** （「設天元一為 X 」）——宣告未知量。以現代記號，等同於「令 $x = X$ 」。
2. 以天元 x 表達所有已知量及關係。
3. 構造兩個相等之表達式（常以不同方法計算同一幾何量），一為「左」式暫存，另一為「同數」。
4. **相消**（「mutual cancellation」）——令兩式相等並化簡，得多項式方程之標準形式。
5. 以開方法求解：開平方、開立方、或更高次之開方。

6.2 Polynomial Notation / 多項式記號

李冶運用籌算板上的位置記法：

- 係數縱向排列，常數項（實）在上。
- 其下： x 之係數（方，「square」），繼以 x^2 （廉，「edge」），繼以 x^3 （隅，「corner」）。
- 更高次：第一廉、第二廉等。
- 負係數以末位斜劃表示。

The Tian Yuan Shu Method

The *tian yuan shu* (天元術, “method of the celestial element”) is the algebraic technique employed throughout the *Ceyuan Haijing*. It is the earliest systematic method in Chinese mathematics for setting up and solving polynomial equations with one unknown.

The procedure follows these steps:

1. **Set the celestial element unity to be X** (“立天元一為 X ”) — This declares the unknown quantity. In modern notation, it is equivalent to “Let $x = X$ ”.
2. Express all given quantities and relationships in terms of the celestial element x .
3. Construct two equal expressions (often representing the same geometric quantity computed by different methods), one designated as the “left” (左) expression and stored temporarily, the other as the “equal number” (同數).
4. **Mutual cancellation** (相消) — Set the two expressions equal and simplify to obtain the polynomial equation in standard form.
5. Solve the equation by root-extraction methods (開方): square-root extraction (開平方), cube-root extraction (開立方), or higher-degree root extraction.

Li Ye uses a positional notation on a counting-rod board:

- Coefficients are arranged vertically, with the constant term (實) at the top.
- Below it: the coefficient of x (方, “square”), then x^2 (廉, “edge”), then x^3 (隅, “corner”).
- For higher degrees: first 廉, second 廉, etc.
- Negative coefficients are indicated by a diagonal stroke through the last digit.

6.3 Example: Quadratic Equation / 示例：二次方程

第一問導出相當於下式之方程：

$$384000 = 1600 \cdot d$$

其中 d 為直徑。但更複雜之問題產生真正的多項式方程。例如卷三第四問產生**三次方程**：

$$(4 \cdot 16)(480)^2 = (480 + 16) \cdot d^2 - d^3$$

以現代形式，李冶以「帶縱立方」解之。

The first problem leads to the equation equivalent to:

$$384000 = 1600 \cdot d$$

where d is the diameter. But more complex problems yield true polynomial equations. For instance, Problem 4 of Volume 3 produces a **cubic equation**:

$$(4 \cdot 16)(480)^2 = (480 + 16) \cdot d^2 - d^3$$

in modern form, which Li Ye solves by “opening the cube with an edge” (帶縱立方).

6.4 Historical Significance / 歷史意義

《測圓海鏡》為現存最早系統運用天元術之著作。所解方程包括：

次數 / Degree	方程數量 / Number
一次 / Linear (degree 1)	31
二次 / Quadratic (degree 2)	106
三次 / Cubic (degree 3)	24
四次 / Quartic (degree 4)	20
六次 / Sextic (degree 6)	1
總計 / Total	182

The *Ceyuan Haijing* is the earliest surviving work that systematically employs the tian yuan shu. The equations solved include:

Degree	Number of Equations
Linear (degree 1)	31
Quadratic (degree 2)	106
Cubic (degree 3)	24
Quartic (degree 4)	20
Sextic (degree 6)	1
Total	182

注：本排印版呈現《測圓海鏡》卷一至卷三之全文。卷一包含全部定義、數值數據及六百九十二條幾何公式。卷二、卷三呈現一百七十問中之首批三十一問，以天元術求解。其餘九卷（卷四–卷十二）繼續一百三十九問，複雜度漸增，至卷七達六次方程。

Note: This typeset edition presents the complete text of Volumes 1–3 of the *Ceyuan Haijing*. Volume 1 contains all definitions, numerical data, and 692 geometric formulas. Volumes 2 and 3 present the first 31 of 170 problems, solved by the tian yuan shu method. The remaining nine volumes (卷四–卷十二) continue with 139 further problems of increasing complexity, culminating in a sixth-degree equation in Volume 7.